Graphic Design

Design for web & social media

Summary Notes

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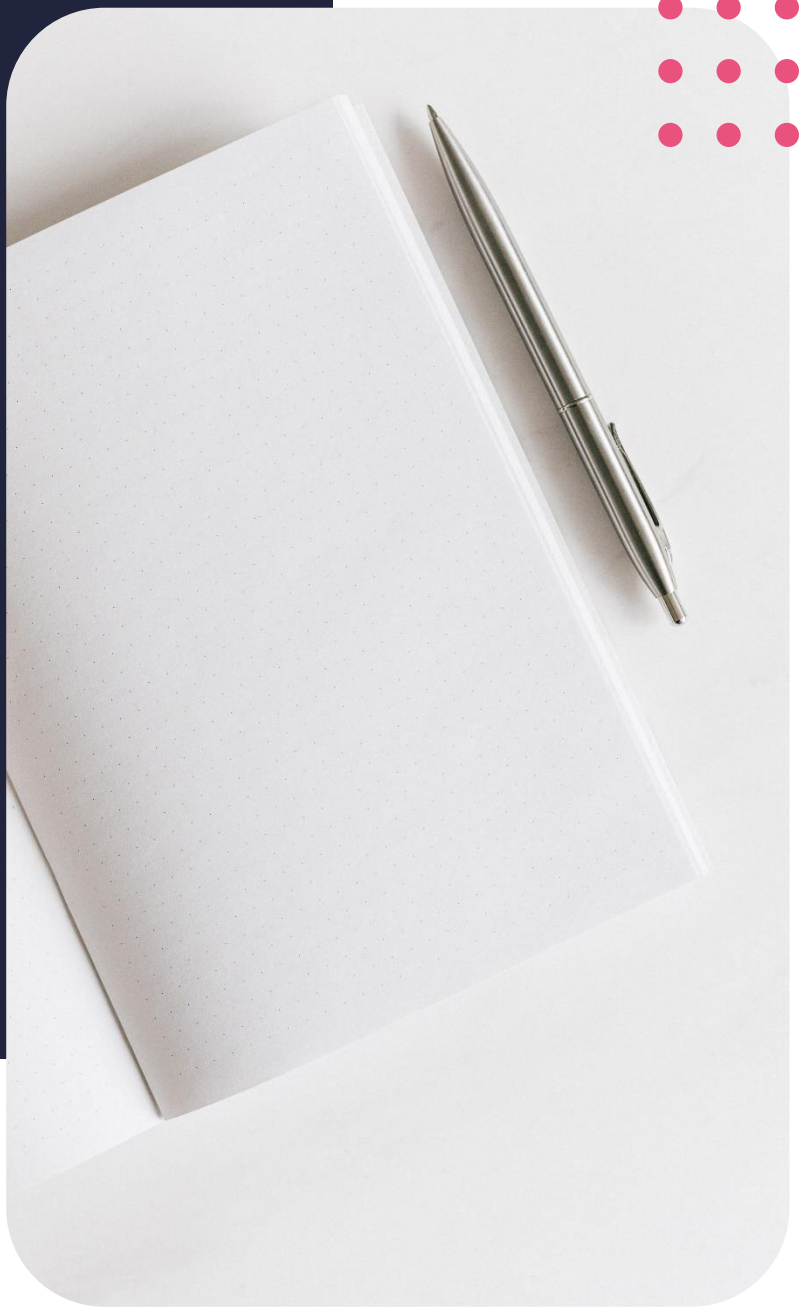


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: What is web design?
- Lesson outcome 2: How do I create a website?
- Lesson outcome 3: What is social media?
- Lesson outcome 4: What are UX & UI?
- Lesson outcome 5: What is usability
- Lesson outcome 6: Applying effective usability
- Lesson outcome 7: Making use of HEX colour
- Lesson outcome 8: Designing for social media

Introduction

Did you know, the first website ever went live on 6 August 1991. It was created by Tim Berners-Lee and ran on a NeXT computer. NeXT computers were created by Steve Jobs after he got forced out of Apple.

This website can still be viewed today here: http://info.cern.ch/hypertext/WWW/TheProject.html

It is important to note that the functionality of your website and social media pages is extremely important. And this is what Steve Jobs also stated: Design is not just what it looks like and feels like. Design is how it works.

You would have noticed that throughout this whole course I have placed quite a lot of emphasis on the term “form follows function”. What Steve Jobs stated here comes down to the functionality of a design. Remember, graphic design is so much more than simply creating something that looks amazing. It is equally important to create a design that is practical and make the process for the viewer more convenient.

What is web design?

Graphic design is visual problem solving and this is so much more evident and crucial when it comes to web designing and social media. Why exactly web design and social media? Because this is where you can experience the practicality of your design firsthand. If posting something on social media does not create the desired response, you will know that you need to change something.

Web design, not to be confused with web development is the process of creating the look and feel of a website.

Web design, not to be confused with web development is the process of creating the look and feel of a website. This has to do with the layout and aesthetics of the website. Think of a web designer as being the architect who creates a building plan for a house.

A web developer on the other hand takes the design made by the web designer to create a functional website. Think of web developers as the builders of the house.

I will not be going into too much detail here, so if you are interested in web design or web development, check out these courses we have to offer. If you are a web designer or developer doing the graphic design course, you would have probably picked up that it will aid you in not only creating functional websites, but professionally looking designed websites as well. On the other hand, it is also handy for graphic designers to know about web design, because when

working with other creatives and professionals, you will need to have an understanding of what their roles entail and how your role fits into the bigger picture.

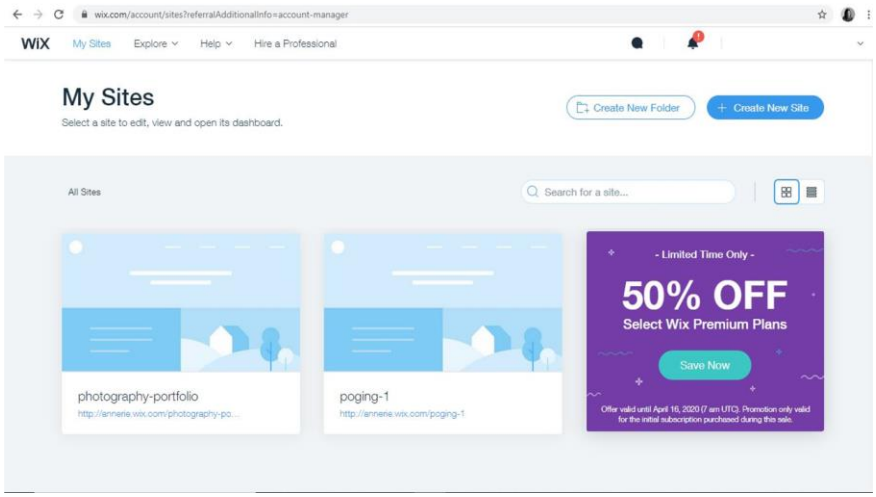
The role of a graphic designer within the web realm will mostly be layout and grid designing – which we have done in our previous modules. You will also focus on the effective use of your elements and principles of design.

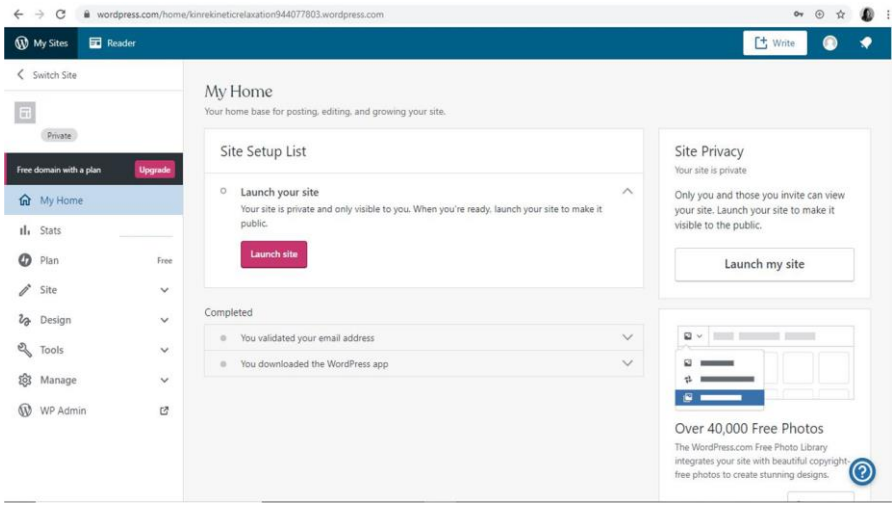
How do I create a website?

Except for working in collaboration with web designers and developers to create a website, graphic designers can also create websites with some handy tools and applications available to us. You do not necessarily need to understand web coding, but it will help a lot if you do. Learning web coding is like learning a new language, it is quite difficult in the beginning but will make your web design process so much more convenient. Kindly note that web coding cannot be learnt in one lesson and thus I would suggest you do the web development course if you are at all interested in web development.

Some of the applications we, as graphic designers can make use of, you have probably heard of before. WordPress and Wix are WYSIWYG editors and allows almost anyone to create amazing looking websites but to add more advanced and customisable features, again, you will need to rely on your web designers and developers.

Now, if you're not into creating a website, you can always rely on social media.





Please refer to video lesson for demo

What is social media?

Social media allows you to create, share and participate with other social media users using a platform like Facebook, Instagram, Twitter or LinkedIn. Since it is free to use and quite user-friendly, it has become a popular option for businesses. Social media has taken the digital world by storm during the last decade and I am sure that you will all agree with me – marketing changed in a matter of only a couple of years. The way we market products and services today differs so much from how we advertised 10 years ago.

Back in the day, if you wanted to make an impression, you would have needed a large marketing budget. Nowadays, social media and digital marketing, makes exposure for small businesses so much more affordable. Considering the cost of a TV advert or billboard, which is not as focused as a Facebook ad or a simple share by a friend, you are able to target your audience more quickly and even be more specific to your target market.

This in return created new problems in the digital marketing space: a lot of noise – so many people selling so many things to you on social media. It is simply difficult to stand out. Therefore, it is extremely important to understand how social media works and which format and size is best to publish your images in.

What are UX & UI?

As the origin of all this, websites started out very basic, evolved and social media platforms were created amongst other digital product. It became widely used and the functionality of these digital products became more apparent.

Websites and social media platforms in return evolved as mobile devices evolved and eventually, these became what we call responsive. The responsiveness of a website or application links to the adjustment of the layout depending on the device you are viewing it on. You can test this by simply going to any website and view it on a computer as well as smartphone – it's the same website, but it looks slightly different. Even changing your phones view from portrait to landscape will also affect the layout. Hence, if this happens, the website you are viewing is responsive.

After websites, the invention of applications on your phone became the next big thing. This allowed for technology to be accessible for more people, as not everyone has a computer.

Soon, it became clear that these websites and applications had to be user-friendly to cater for the large audience it serves. UX refers to user experience – how the product or application feels. UI refers to user interface design – how the product or application looks. Both these terms link to the usability of software and applications including websites and mobile apps. Thus, these designers' role is to make the product or application seem as second nature to its user.

Eventually, since apps can be referred to as modern products, UX & UI designers can be considered as product designers.

Can you see how this process links into the broader spectrum of visual communication solving a problem? How product and web designers need to make the function of these products as accessible as possible.

What is usability?

The purpose of your website or social media page should thus be user focused. The aim of a digital product is to communicate effectively. Since social media platforms have a general layout where users simply generate content to add to the layout, you can focus on your actual post and make sure that it communicates effectively.

When designing for web or social media, always consider the user experience your viewer will have. The following should be considered to make your digital product user-friendly:

Your product should be easy to read and digest – make use of columns of text; remember people don't want to read a lot, so entice them with digestible pieces of information.

The information displayed in your product should be organised – consider your knowledge on the visual hierarchy you learnt in previous lessons.

Make effective use of headlines and sub-headings. This will provide your viewer or user with visual clues on whether they are interested to read the material.

Make use of bullet points as this is easier to digest than paragraphs of text

Infographics are a great way to stimulate your viewer and help them to memorise information easier. We will get to the process of creating infographics in our next lesson.

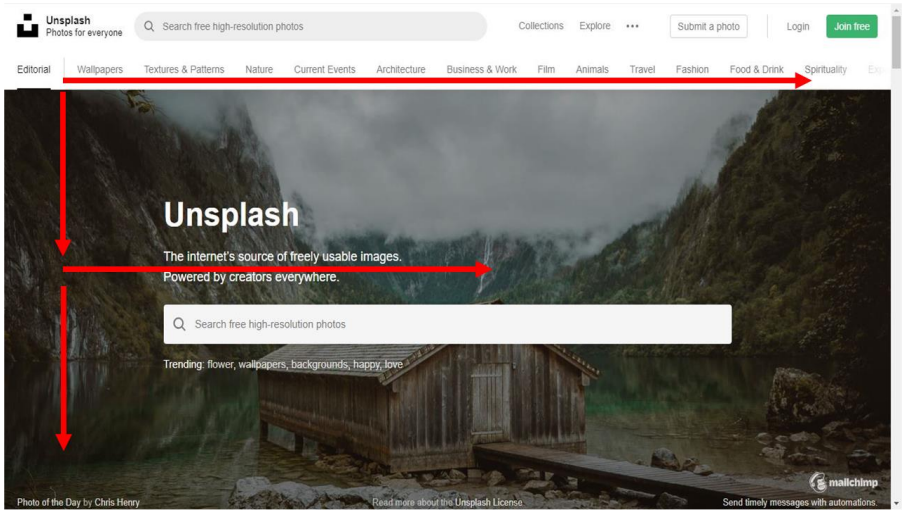
Lastly, keep it simple and to the point. Your viewer does not want to read an essay.

Applying effective usability

Applying effective usability should not be a problem if you have been following the lessons and tasks that I have been providing you throughout this course. A lot of what have said so far in this lesson, and what I will be saying how, have been said before – it links to the basics of design and I want you to understand that these basics can be applied to any form of design, not just graphic design. Thus, your elements and principles of design should by now be second nature and something you apply by habit.

Aspects to consider when designing for web are;

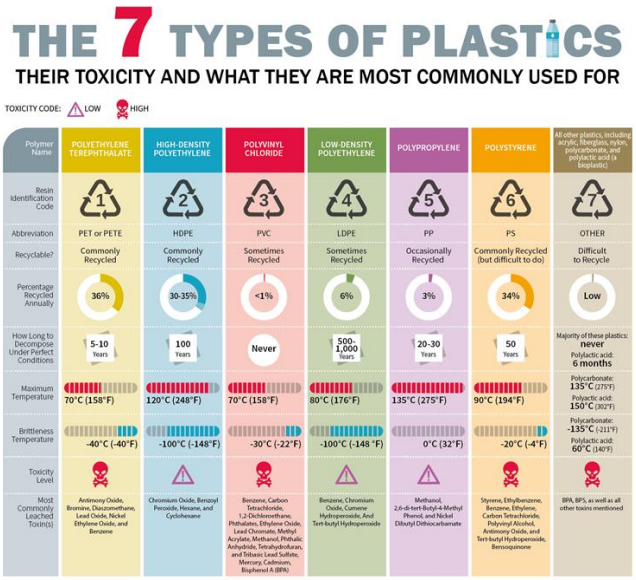
Make use of the F-layout



Reiterating the principle that we read from left to right, and top to bottom, this is what the f-layout in web design terms relate to. Next time you have a website or application open, see if you can identify whether the f-layout has been adapted.

The f-layout works because it considers the way Westerners, and a large portion of the rest of the world read and view things. Understand that you do not need to reinvent the wheel. If it works, make it work for your design as well.

You might have heard of infographics and I'm excited to share with you that we will learn the skill of creating infographics in our upcoming lessons.



Infographic: https://infographicjournal.com/7-types-of-plastics-their-toxicity-what-theyre-most-commonly-used-for/

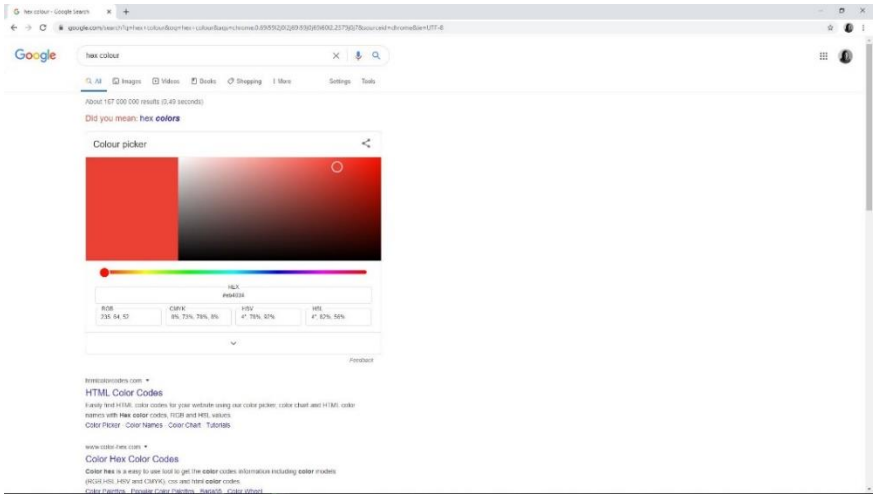
This is only half of the infographic relating to our packaging lesson. You can download this infographic from Infographic Journal. Now, instead of displaying given information in a bullet list, an infographic makes the information a lot more digestible.

Lastly, *keep it simple and to the point*. Provide only the necessary detail for your viewer and don't bore them with irrelevant information. Also remember that web design is about 90% typography, so apply the considerations that you have learnt about typography during this course. Your type should be legible and leave enough spacing to make it easier to read. Also, viewers prefer static websites to moving and flashing banners – this just looks cheap, so keep it simple.

Making use of HEX colour

Moving on to the topic of colour, which I'm sure you are well familiar with by now. When designing for web, we make use of a different colour model than CMYK. Yes, we save our work in RGB format, but choosing colours, we make use of the HEX colour model.

Why is this? Because simply asking someone to show you the colour red, we will all provide different shades and hues of red. Colour codes make it a standard and using a specific code, like we learnt with the Pantone Colour system, everyone will speak the same language and there will be no confusion.



Please refer to video lesson for demo

It is luckily not as complicated as it may seem and you can make use of your design software like Illustrator, Photoshop and InDesign to obtain the Hex colour code, or you can simply google the wording “hex colour” to reveal Google’s colour picker for not only Hex colours but RGB and CMYK as well.

Now, these colours come in handy when you need to copy and paste colours for when you need specific colours for logos and other design that you must adhere to.

Designing for social media

Have you ever realised that when uploading a photo to Facebook or Instagram, for example, that the quality gets reduced drastically – this is simply not how you remembered the image. Well, first, you need to understand that there is a reason for this. Imagine millions of people uploading images to their favourite social media platform daily. How much capacity do you think these platforms need in order to store all these images?

Social media platforms reduce the size of images being uploaded to save space and make the process as quick as possible. I would like to leave you with key guidelines for Facebook and Instagram specifically when it comes to saving and designing for web.

This will ensure that your images stay crisp and clear and thus do not lose quality in the uploading process.

For both Facebook and Instagram, make sure your images are either saved as Jpg format for continuous tones, like photographs or PNG for flat colours images or type. Since it is for digital purposes, your images should be saved as RGB colour mode. Kindly note that saving a file as a png will also preserve the transparency, which I will show you in our brief demo later.

Make use of Photoshop to convert your images into Facebook compatible images.

Now, these steps remain the same irrespective of whether you are saving a profile picture or a normal post, to Facebook or Instagram. The next step is to make sure you have the correct dimensions.

Saving images for Facebook:

When you have a profile picture for Facebook, make sure that its ratio is 1:1 and the pixel dimensions are 2048px for optimum quality

A Facebook page cover photo should be 1958px wide by 745px high and when you create a new post on your page’s news feed, simply make sure your image width is 2048px, irrespective of the height.

Also, refer to www.postplanner.com for more dimensions to stay updated with the most accurate dimensions for posting to Facebook.

Saving images for Instagram:

Perfect dimensions for Instagram include

Square: 600px x 600px & 1936px x 1936px (ratio 1:1)

Landscape: 600px x 315px & 1936px x 1014px (ratio 1,91:1)

Portrait: 600px x 750px & 1936px 2420px (ratio 4:5)

Kindly note that these dimensions might change from time to time, so it is crucial that you always keep up with the latest trends by doing research.

Let’s look at how you will go about saving a social media image making use of Photoshop.

Please refer to video lesson for demo

Conclusion

Even though this lesson was packed with a lot of theory, every single part is crucial and when put into practice, you will realise why.

Our lesson today entailed all aspects of designing for web and social media.

We learnt that there is a difference between web designers and developers and how you, as a graphic designer can work with them. We also looked at how Social media came into being and considered the user interface and experience for product design.

We realised that the HEX colour code is an accurate way to communicate specific colours to other digital designers and we ended off with sizing our images for web to ensure we get the best quality – size in this case, is not always linked to quality.

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